successful Arab soccer player, then we don't have a problem. But we have a problem," Lapid added.

Israel skirted the problem for decades by leaving the law deliberately vague. A Jewish state should observe the Sabbath, so public transportation halts on Friday evening, and the prime minister avoids publicly desecrating the day of rest, no matter what he does in private. But a democratic state should not force its citizens to sit at home, so it allows local governments to enforce their own Shabbat laws. In secular Tel Aviv, a supermarket that opens on Saturday receives a fine of just $200—and only when one of the city's handful of overworked inspectors happens to pay a visit. Bars and cafes are packed. In ultra-Orthodox communities, meanwhile, nobody would think of working on the sabbath.

In 2014, though, Netanyahu decided to end the ambiguity. He first proposed a "nation-state bill" in May, but the initiative quickly stalled along with the rest of the Knesset's business: the kidnapping and murder of three Israeli teens in the West Bank, then the Gaza war, overshadowed all policymaking. The prime minister revived the idea six months later, after Palestinian gunmen attacked the Har Nof synagogue. He announced his plan in mid-November, and introduced a formal draft at a cabinet meeting on 26 November. "[Israel] has equal individual rights for every citizen and we insist on this. But only the Jewish people have national rights: A flag, an anthem, the right of every Jew to immigrate to the country, and other national symbols," he said at the meeting. "These are granted only to our people, in its one and only state."

His vague announcement was widely seen as a sop to the conservative elements in his coalition, particularly Bennett, who was vying to position himself as the next leader of the Israeli right. It was met with trepidation by Israeli liberals. "Is this an empty slogan? Then I'm for it. If it includes specific changes in our life, in order to minimize our liberal public sphere, then I'm against it," said Yedidia Stern, a vice president at the Israel Democracy Institute, a group that is one of Israel's most principled voices for equality.

Stern offered a few examples of what might make the law objectionable: if it designated Hebrew as the only official language, or if it directed judges to interpret Israeli law according to "*halakhic* values", or Jewish religious law.